Little Red Riding Hood



Chapter 1: The Crimson Shroud



In a village where the mist clung to the cobblestones like a damp shroud, there lived a girl of such porcelain beauty that she seemed carved from the winter frost. Her mother, a woman haunted by the shadows of the woods, doted on her with a feverish intensity. To protect her from the village's gaze, she draped the girl in a cloak of heavy, blood-red velvet—a garment that seemed to drink the light around it. The villagers whispered that the red was not merely a color, but a ward against the things that prowled in the periphery of the world.

One evening, as the wind howled through the eaves like a dying beast, the mother handed the girl a parcel wrapped in linen. Inside lay cakes baked with herbs for sleep and a small jar of tallow.

"Your grandmother is fading," the mother whispered, her eyes wide and rimmed with red. "The sickness of the woods has taken her strength. Take these. Do not linger. Do not listen to the whispers of the trees. Go, and return before the moon reaches its zenith."

Chapter 2: The Whispering Woods



The forest was not a place of birdsong, but of creaking timber and the heavy scent of rot. The girl moved with a rhythmic gait, her red cloak billowing behind her like a trail of drying blood. It was here, where the trees grew so thick they strangled one another, that she encountered the Wolf.

He did not emerge from the brush; he simply *was* there, a towering silhouette of grey fur and yellow eyes that burned like dying embers. He was a creature of the old world, a shadow given teeth. He could have struck then, but the scent of iron—the forge-fires of the nearby woodsmen—kept him at bay.

"A little bird in a red nest," the Wolf purred, his voice a low vibration that rattled the girl's ribs. "Where do you fly, little morsel?"

The girl, mesmerized by the velvet texture of his voice—a sound like honey poured over gravel—forgot her mother's warnings. "I go to my grandmother's cottage," she replied. "She is ill, and I bear her sustenance."

"Is she far?" the Wolf asked, his tail twitching with a hungry, predatory rhythm.

"Beyond the mill," she said, pointing toward the skeletal remains of the waterwheel. "At the first house where the lilies grow white as bone."

"Then we shall race," the Wolf chuckled. "I shall take the path of the thorn, and you the path of the flower. We shall see who reaches the door first."

Chapter 3: The Tallow and the Teeth



The Wolf moved with the grace of a nightmare, gliding over the loam. He reached the cottage first, its roof sagging like a tired eyelid. He did not merely knock; he struck the wood with a heavy, deliberate thud.

"Who is there?" a voice crackled from within—thin and brittle as dry leaves.

"Your grandchild," the Wolf hissed, imitating a voice that was far too melodic to be human. "I bring the cakes and the tallow. Open the latch."

The grandmother, shivering in her fever-bed, commanded the bolt to be pulled. The Wolf entered, a shadow pouring into a room. He did not hesitate. He became a blur of grey and t

eeth, silencing the old woman in a s

ingular, wet crunch of bone and wool. He retreated to the bed, pulling the heavy quilts over his bulk, masking the scent of iron with the smell of old dust.

A while later, the girl arrived. She stopped at the door, her heart hammering against her ribs. The voice that answered was deep, distorted by a wetness that made her skin crawl.

"It is I, your grandchild," she whispered. "I have brought the gifts."

"Pull the peg, my child," the Wolf croaked, straining to keep his voice from breaking into a howl. "The bolt will fall."

The girl entered. The room smelled of lilies and something metallic. She saw the figure beneath the quilts—a mountain of trembling fabric.

"Grand-mamma," she said, her voice trembling. "Your arms are so large."

"That is to hold you closer, my dear."

"Grand-mamma, your legs are so heavy."

"That is to run faster to your side, my child."

"Grand-mamma, your ears are so pointed."

"That is to hear your heartbeat better, my child."

"Grand-mamma, your eyes are so bright."

"That is to see your beauty in the dark."

"Grand-mamma... your teeth are so sharp."

"That is to ensure you never leave me."

The quilts flew back. The Wolf’s jaws unhinged, a ca

vern of needle-teeth and black gullet. The red cloak was the last thing the forest saw of her—a flicker of crimson swallowed by the grey.

The Moral

Let the young and the fair take heed of the forest’s craft. For the Wolf is not always a beast of fur and claw. He is the silver tongue in the marketplace, the smooth-talker in the tavern, and the smiling face that lures the soul toward the precipice. Beware the predator who offers a melody, for the sweetest songs are often t

he ones that lead to the slaughter.